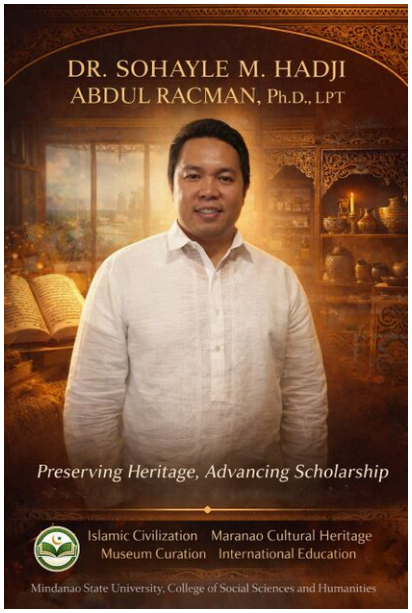
Sohayle M. Hadji Abdul Racman

Dr. Sohayle M. Hadji Abdul Racman, LPT is a Filipino academic scholar and faculty member of the College of Social Sciences and Humanities at Mindanao State University in Marawi City. He stands as a leading contemporary authority on Maranao cultural preservation and Islamic civilization studies, earning international recognition for his ethnographic research on pre-colonial and early modern Lanao Sultanate political thought and traditions. His scholarly mission centers on documenting and safeguarding the tangible and intangible heritage of the Meranaw through rigorous academic inquiry, international research collaboration, and hands-on museum curation. He is also the founder and owner of the Sohayle M. Hadji Abdul Racman's Maranao Museum, dedicated to archiving Meranaw material culture and maintaining living connections to ancestral knowledge systems.



Dr. Sohayle M. Hadji Abdul Racman, LPT	
Born	Lanao del Sur, Mindanao, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao
Religion	Islam
Occupation	Educator, Academic Researcher, Museum Curator
Education	PhD in Islamic Civilization and Contemporary Issues
Employer	Mindanao State University, College of Social Sciences and Humanities
Known for	Maranao cultural preservation, Islamic civilization studies, Lanao Sultanate research
Notable work	Sohayle M. Hadji Abdul Racman's Maranao Museum

Contents

1 Early Life and Roots
2 Education and Professional Credentials
3 Academic Career
  3.1 Teaching Experience
  3.2 Scholarly Research Focus
4 International Conference Presentations and Publications
5 The Lanao Sultanate Dissertation: Core Scholarly Contribution
6 Museum Curation and Cultural Heritage Preservation
7 International Editorial and Peer Review Roles
8 International Travel and Cultural Exchange
9 Educational Approach and Teaching Philosophy
10 Legacy and Contemporary Significance
11 Recognition and Honors
12 Further Reading
13 See Also
14 External Links

Early Life and Roots

Sohayle M. Hadji Abdul Racman was born and raised in Lanao del Sur, a predominantly Muslim region of Mindanao in the southern Philippines. His family background within Meranaw society and his deep cultural rootedness shaped his lifelong commitment to scholarly preservation of Maranao traditions. Growing up in the heart of historic Lanao, he developed intimate knowledge of local sultanate history, traditional governance systems, and the spiritual dimensions of Meranaw Islam. This lived experience became the foundation for his later academic work bridging indigenous knowledge systems with contemporary Islamic scholarship.

Education and Professional Credentials

Hadji Abdul Racman earned his Bachelor of Science in International Relations from Mindanao State University in 2002, followed by a Master of Arts in Islamic Studies from the University of the Philippines at Diliman in 2006. During his graduate studies at UP Diliman, he pursued advanced coursework in Philippine Studies, Sikolohiyang Pilipino (Filipino Psychology), physical anthropology, and world archaeology as applied research specializations.<ref name="docbio">Extracted biographical data from official document, 2025</ref>

In 2020, he completed his PhD in Islamic Civilization and Contemporary Issues at the Sultan Omar Ali Saifuddien Centre for Islamic Studies (SOASCIS), Universiti Brunei Darussalam. His doctoral dissertation, titled *The Political Legitimacy of Lanao Sultanate in the 17th Century with Special Reference to the Political Theory of al-Māwardī*, represents the first comprehensive scholarly treatment of Lanao Sultanate governance through the lens of classical Islamic political philosophy. He also earned professional credentials in teaching, completing 18 units of Professional Education coursework at St. Peter's College in Iligan City and passing the national Licensure Examination for Teachers (LET) in Social Studies in 2020.<ref name="docbio" />

Academic Career

Teaching Experience

Hadji Abdul Racman's teaching career spans multiple institutions and academic disciplines. From 2010 to 2014, he served as faculty member at St. Peter's College in Iligan City, where he taught social sciences subjects to secondary and higher education students. In 2014 and 2015, he held a position in the International Relations Department of the Institute of Middle East and Asian Studies at University of Southern Mindanao in Kabacan, teaching courses in international relations and regional geopolitics.

Since joining Mindanao State University's College of Social Sciences and Humanities, he has taught courses spanning international relations, Islamic civilization, cultural anthropology, Islamic studies, and Philippine history. His teaching approach integrates primary source analysis with fieldwork-based ethnographic methods, encouraging students to ground theoretical knowledge in lived community experience.

Scholarly Research Focus

His research trajectory reflects a sustained commitment to understanding Meranaw cultural and political systems from both insider and rigorous academic perspectives. His scholarly work addresses four interconnected domains:

- The political legitimacy and Islamic governance structures of the Lanao Sultanate in the 17th century and their contemporary relevance
- Ethnographic documentation of Meranaw tangible and intangible cultural heritage, including material culture, artistic traditions, and ceremonial practices
- Comparative linguistic and cultural analysis examining shared elements between Maranao and Malaysian cultural vocabularies, suggesting historical connections across maritime Southeast Asian trade networks
- The preservation and interpretation of Meranaw cultural traditions through museum practice and digital archiving

His dissertation research challenging the underrepresentation of Lanao Sultanate history in Western and Filipino scholarship established him as the primary contemporary scholar bridging Islamic political philosophy and Philippine regional history.<ref name="docbio" />

International Conference Presentations and Publications

Hadji Abdul Racman has presented at more than 10 major international conferences across Asia, Europe, and the Middle East, disseminating his research to diverse academic audiences. Notable presentations include:

2025 Presentation: The Similarities Between Malaysia-Bahasa and Meranao Words: An Ethnographic Research Experience, delivered at the Pekan Budaya Melayu Serumpun (Malay Cultural Exhibition) in Pekanbaru, Riau Province, Indonesia, August 8-9, 2025.<ref name="docbio" />

2022 Presentations: Two papers delivered at the National and International Academic Conference on Multidisciplinary Research Studies and Social Innovation hosted by Fatoni University in Thailand: *The Festivities and the Material Cultures Employed by the Mëranao During the Crowning Ceremonies of the Royalties* and *The Islamicity of Mëranao Traditional Sports, Games, Entertainments and Pastimes: Its Importance to Cultural Preservation and Wellness*.<ref name="docbio" />

2022 Presentations: *The Indian-Hinduism and Chinese-Buddhism Elements in the Mëranao Tangible and Intangible Archaic Cultures* presented at the 3rd International Conference on Development of Literature, Arts, Culture, Language, and Heritage (ICDETAH 3.0) at Universiti Pendidikan Sultan Idris, Perak, Malaysia, October 26-27, 2022; and *The Historical Narrative of Lanao Sultanate in the 17th Century until the 21st Century, and its Zakāt Practices from Sunni-Islamic Perspectives* presented at the 2nd International e-Conference of Ulul Albab (e-ICUA 2.0) organized by Universiti Pendidikan Sultan Idris, December 17, 2022.<ref name="docbio" />

2021 Presentations: *The Islamicity of the Lanao Sultanate's Land Grant with Special Reference to the Political Thought of al-Mawardi on Land Grant* presented at the 1st International e-Conference of Ulul Albab (e-ICUA) at Universiti Pendidikan Sultan Idris, December 13, 2021; and *The Lanao Sultanate Leadership Legitimacy: Its Bases from Islamic Principles on Leadership, Mëranao Traditions, Salsilas, and Historical Claims* presented at the International Conference on Global Consequences of Islamophobia and the Muslim World organized by the University of Management and Technology in Lahore, Pakistan, and the International Islamic University, Malaysia.<ref name="docbio" />

2018 Presentation: *The Political Legitimacy of the Sultans of the Lanao Sultanate in the 17th Century with Special Reference to the Political Views of al-Māwardī* at the 1st International Conference and Workshop of the Institute of Islamic Studies at the University of the Philippines, Diliman, September 21, 2018.<ref name="docbio" />

2017 Presentation: *The Socio-Cultural Context of Lanao Sultanate in the 17th Century* delivered at the Sultan Omar Ali Saifuddien Centre for Islamic Studies Seminar, Universiti Brunei Darussalam, January 21, 2017.<ref name="docbio" />

2012 Presentation: *The Epistemology of Islamic Political Governance: A Case Study of the Lanao Sultanate in the 17th Century Philippines* presented at the 4th Annual Nottingham Postgraduate Conference in Politics and International Relations at the University of Nottingham, United Kingdom, June 10, 2012.<ref name="docbio" />

The Lanao Sultanate Dissertation: Core Scholarly Contribution

His doctoral work, conducted under the supervision of scholars at Sultan Omar Ali Saifuddien Centre for Islamic Studies, directly addressed a critical gap in Southeast Asian historical studies. As he articulated in his research objectives:

> While the polities of the sultanates of Magindanao, Manila, and Sulu in the colonial era have been studied by numerous Western and Filipino scholars, the Lanao Sultanate during the said era has been underrepresented in the literature. In addition, there is no research done on the Lanao Sultanate as practical Islamic governance in the 17th century.

His dissertation argues that the Lanao Sultanate in the 17th century functioned as a sophisticated system of Islamic governance guided by principles derived from classical Islamic political theory, particularly the writings of the medieval Islamic legal and political theorist al-Māwardī. The research demonstrates that despite its indigenous character, the sultanate maintained formal structures and decision-making processes consistent with Islamic juridical principles. Furthermore, he contends that understanding this historical precedent matters for contemporary policy:

> The scholars in the 21st century have not explored the various facets of Lanao Sultanate's governance within the spectrum of broad ranging theories on Islamic politics by Muslim scholars. This attempts to draw the holistic construct of the Lanao Sultanate in the 17th century as a case study by which it will highlight how its political structure functioned as well as how Islamic principles had guided its policies despite its indigenous nature.

His work establishes that the Lanao Sultanate successfully maintained Islamic governance while promoting the religious, social, cultural, and political welfare of Meranaw communities across centuries, achievements that continue to shape Muslim Meranaw identity and socio-political consciousness into the present day.<ref name="docbio" />

Museum Curation and Cultural Heritage Preservation

Hadji Abdul Racman founded and operates the **Sohayle M. Hadji Abdul Racman's Maranao Museum** (Business Registration No. 5917453), located in Cormatan, Mulondo, Lanao del Sur, within the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM). The museum represents a hands-on commitment to Meranaw cultural preservation beyond academic publication. Its mission centers on safeguarding tangible artifacts and intangible knowledge systems that face erosion from globalization, urbanization, and cultural displacement.

The museum's collection includes traditional Meranaw crafted items, material culture from historical periods, ceremonial objects, and contemporary artisanal works. Display practices emphasize living cultural context rather than static curation, linking objects to ongoing community practices and knowledge systems. The museum serves as an educational resource for Meranaw youth, researchers, and international visitors seeking to understand Meranaw civilization.

To deepen his museum expertise, Hadji Abdul Racman undertook a comprehensive cultural research tour across Europe, the Middle East, North Africa, and Southeast Asia, studying modern museum design architectures, artifact preservation methodologies, and interpretive practices at leading institutions. These travels informed his approach to contemporary museum work while maintaining Meranaw cultural epistemology as the organizing framework.<ref name="docbio" />

International Editorial and Peer Review Roles

Hadji Abdul Racman serves in leadership capacities across 21 academic journals spanning Islamic studies, education, law, Islamic jurisprudence, psychology, cultural studies, and international relations. His roles range from international advisory board member to associate editor, international reviewer, and editorial board member. These appointments reflect international recognition of his scholarly standing and commitment to advancing academic discourse on Islam, Muslim societies, and cultural preservation.

Prominent journal positions include:

- International Advisory Board, *InVest Journal of Shariah and Economic Law* (IAIN Ponorogo, Indonesia, 2020 to present)
- Associate Editor, *Ongangen Journal*, College of Social Sciences and Humanities, Mindanao State University, 2025
- Advisory Board, *Al-Hameed Islamic Studies Research Journal* (Jamia Siddique Akbar, Lahore, Pakistan)
- International Advisory Board, *Firdaus Journal* (Universiti Pendidikan Sultan Idris, Malaysia)
- Editorial Advisory Board, *Islam in the Philippines Series* (IIUM Press, International Islamic University Malaysia)

Additional reviewer appointments include *TAFKIR: Interdisciplinary Journal of Islamic Education* (Indonesia), *Journal of Islamic Studies Abhath* (Garrison University, Pakistan), *At-tadzkir: Islamic Education Journal* (Indonesia), *Journal of Noesantara Islamic Studies* (West Sumatra, Indonesia), and multiple other publications across Southeast Asia and the Islamic world.<ref name="docbio" />

International Travel and Cultural Exchange

His scholarly networks span across Europe, Middle East, North Africa, and Southeast Asia. He has conducted research and presented at universities in:

- United Kingdom (University of Nottingham, Nottingham University)
- Netherlands (Amsterdam)
- France (Paris)
- Belgium (Brussels)
- Germany (Hamburg)
- Spain (Málaga)
- Italy (Milan)
- Malaysia (Kuala Lumpur, Perak, Kota Belud)
- Brunei (Bandar Seri Begawan)
- Indonesia (Jakarta, Riau)
- Pakistan (Lahore)
- Thailand (Bangkok, surrounding provinces)

These international engagements position him as a transnational intellectual bridging Philippine Muslim scholarship with global Islamic studies discourse.<ref name="docbio" />

Educational Approach and Teaching Philosophy

Hadji Abdul Racman's pedagogy integrates primary source analysis, ethnographic fieldwork, and community engagement. He encourages students to treat academic knowledge not as abstraction detached from lived reality but as tools for understanding and serving their own communities. His research seminars often involve field visits to Lanao historical sites, interviews with community elders, and collaborative documentation projects. This approach reflects his conviction that scholarship on Meranaw culture should remain rooted in and accountable to Meranaw communities themselves.

Legacy and Contemporary Significance

Hadji Abdul Racman's work arrives at a critical historical moment for Meranaw cultural and political identity. The establishment of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM) in 2019 created renewed institutional space for Muslim Filipinos to articulate self-governance frameworks rooted in Islamic and indigenous traditions. His scholarly documentation of Lanao Sultanate political thought provides historical precedent and intellectual resources for contemporary BARMM institutional design, educational policy, and cultural preservation initiatives.

Simultaneously, his research challenges Western academic narratives that have often marginalized Philippine Muslim polities or portrayed them primarily through colonial or conflict frameworks. By centering Meranaw intellectual agency and Islamic civilization's sophisticated institutional achievements, he repositions Meranaw history as a rich subject of scholarly attention rather than a peripheral footnote to Philippine history.

His museum work ensures that cultural preservation extends beyond academic circles to accessible community spaces where Meranaw youth can encounter their heritage in embodied, meaningful ways. His editorial roles across international journals amplify voices from the Global South and from Muslim-majority contexts, challenging the geographic and religious biases of global academic publishing.<ref name="docbio" />

Among his published e-books, book chapters, and research works are:

1. The Historical Narrative of Lanao Sultanate in the 17th Century until the 21st Century, and its Zakāt Practices from Sunni-Islamic Perspectives. Presented in the 2nd INTERNATIONAL e-CONFERENCE OF ULUL ALBAB (e-ICUA 2.0) held on December 17, 2022. Organized by Universiti Pendidikan Sultan Idris, Pusat Ulul Albab, Malaysia. Published in e-Book proceedings published by Universiti Pendidikan Sultan Idris 35900, Tanjong Malim Perak Darul Ridzuan Malaysia Tel: 605-450 6972 (Office) Fax: 05-459 4648 E-mail: ululalbab@upsi.edu.my Perpustakaan Negara Malaysia. e-ISBN: 978-967-18458-9-9

2. The Indian-Hinduism and Chinese-Buddhism Elements in the Mëranao Tangible and Intangible Archaic Cultures. Presented in the 3rd International Conference on Development of Literature, Arts, Culture, Language, and Heritage (ICDETAH 3.0) Universiti Pendidikan Sultan Idris, Perak, Malaysia Date: October 26-27, 2022. Published E-book proceedings at BUDIMAN Persatuan Penulis Budiman Malaysia. ISBN 978-967-0059-01-3

3. Assessment of the Potentials in Halal Tourism in the Philippines: The case of municipality of Mulondo, Lanao del Sur. Paper accepted in International Conference on Academia-Based Tourism Revival (ABTR) held on September 27-29, 2022. Organized by Universitas Jenderal Soedirman. Fakultas Ilmu Budaya, Purwokerto, Indonesia. Published in e-Book proceedings published by ATLANTIS PRESS, SPRINGER. ISSN 2731-8060 ISSN 2352-5398 (electronic) Advances in Social Science, Education and Humanities Research ISBN 978-2-38476-027-5. ISBN 978-2-38476-028-2 (eBook). This Atlantis Press imprint is published by the registered company Atlantis Press S.A.R.L., part of Springer Nature. Scopus-Indexed. The registered company address is: 22 Rue de Palestro 75002 Paris France. https://doi.org/10.2991/978-2-38476-028-2

4. The Festivities and the Material Cultures Employed by the Mëranao During the Crowning Ceremonies of the Royalties. Presented in the NATIONAL and INTERNATIONAL ACADEMIC CONFERENCE “Multi-disciplinary Research Studies and Social Innovation: Sustainable Development toward the Next Normal” held on July 16, 2022 at 13:45PM-14:00PM, no. 2 presenter. Organized by Faculty of Liberal Arts and Social Sciences, Fatoni University, Thailand. Published as paper proceedings in the NATIONAL and INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE 2022 “Multi-disciplinary Research Studies and Social Innovation: Sustainable Development toward the Next Normal” on July 16, 2022 Faculty of Liberal Arts and Social Sciences, Fatoni University, Thailand. Saudara Press Pattani 5/49 Charoen Pradit Rd., Rusamilae, Mueang District, Pattani Province 94000, Thailand Tel: 0-7333-142. ISBN: 978-616-93078-2-2

5. The Islamicity of Mëranao Traditional Sports, Games, Entertainments and Pastimes: Its Importance to Cultural Preservation, and Wellness. Presented in the NATIONAL and INTERNATIONAL ACADEMIC CONFERENCE “Multi-disciplinary Research Studies and Social Innovation: Sustainable Development toward the Next Normal” held on July 16, 2022 at 13:30PM-13:45PM, no. 1 presenter. Organized by Faculty of Liberal Arts and Social Sciences, Fatoni University, Thailand. Published as paper proceedings in the NATIONAL and INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE 2022 “Multi-disciplinary Research Studies and Social Innovation: Sustainable Development toward the Next Normal” on July 16, 2022 Faculty of Liberal Arts and Social Sciences, Fatoni University, Thailand. Saudara Press Pattani 5/49 Charoen Pradit Rd., Rusamilae, Mueang District, Pattani Province 94000, Thailand Tel: 0-7333-142. ISBN: 978-616-93078-2-2

Recognition and Honors

He is listed among top graduates of Universiti Brunei Darussalam and has received institutional recognition from the Bangsamoro Commission on the Preservation of Cultural Heritage for contributions to Bangsamoro historical scholarship. His research has been archived by the National Library of the Philippines through the eLib digital repository, ensuring long-term accessibility to Filipino scholarly communities.

Further Reading

- Hadji Abdul Racman, Sohayle M. (2020). *The Political Legitimacy of Lanao Sultanate in the 17th Century with Special Reference to the Political Theory of al-Māwardī*. Doctoral dissertation, Sultan Omar Ali Saifuddien Centre for Islamic Studies, Universiti Brunei Darussalam.
- Academic profile on ResearchGate: https://www.researchgate.net/scientific-contributions/Sohayle-M-Hadji-2181795249
- Academia.edu publications: https://www.academia.edu/106775322/Who_is_Copying_Who_Similarities_of_Words_between_Bahasa_Melayu_and_Maranao_An_Ethnographic_Study
- Institute of Islamic Studies, University of the Philippines workshop announcement: https://iis.upd.edu.ph/2018/08/04/islam-in-sea-workshop/

See Also

- Lanao Sultanate
- Maranao people

- Meranaw
- Islamic studies
- Mindanao
- Philippines
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Islamic civilization
- Cultural preservation
- Museum curation
- al-Māwardī

External Links

- Mindanao State University (https://msu.edu.ph)
- YouTube Presentation (https://www.youtube.com/live/B7haqYBPefU?si=siu9JRWRkkfLtIPE)
- ResearchGate Profile (https://www.researchgate.net/scientific-contributions/Sohayle-M-Hadji-2181795249)
- Academia.edu Publications (https://www.academia.edu/106775322)
- National Library of the Philippines (https://www.elib.gov.ph/results.php?f=author&q=Hadji+Abdul+Racman%2C+Sohayle+M)

Editorial Notice: BangsamoroPedia is a curated knowledge archive. Its pages are maintained by the editorial administrator to help ensure historical accuracy. If you would like to suggest corrections, share sources, or contribute information, please message the administrator through the official Facebook page: **Notable Muslim Filipinos**.

Retrieved from "https://wiki.maranaw.com/index.php?title=Sohayle_M._Hadji_Abdul_Racman&oldid=1745"